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Goodness Apple

Making paraplegics ‘stand on their feet'

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Just because we can’t walk, we shouldn’t lose hope, says Jonathan Sigworth

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— Photo: K.R. Deepak



Jonathan Sigworth from the US interacting with a spinal injury patient at a workshop in Visakhapatnam

VISAKHAPATNAM, India: Most of those who suffer spinal injuries either curse their fate or conclude that life is doomed forever. There are, however, some who see it as an opportunity to serve others.

Jonathan Sigworth belongs to that rare breed of men, who is determined to see a smile on the faces of others even if that means exerting his frail body to the hilt. All of 23, the young man from the US has been touring all over India trying to make paraplegics ‘stand on their feet’. It’s no easy task but he instils confidence in them through his demonstrations and examples from his own experience.

One morning in February 2006, Jonathan was going up a hill at Mussorie near Delhi on his bicycle. He slipped and fell to the ground from a height of 70 feet. His first question to the doctor was: ‘Can I ever walk again’? He

was depressed when the doctor replied that he would only be able to move his toes. A devout Christian, he said to himself: "If I walk, it would be great, even otherwise it's okay as God must have had other plans for me."

Back in the US, his friend Andrew demonstrated bed mobility for paraplegics.

"The main difference between India and the US in dealing with paraplegics is their rehabilitation. Unlike in the US, there are hardly any rehabilitation facilities for them in India and I decided to create awareness in this regard.

"These techniques take a long time and they are like gymnastics for spinal injury patients. During my last visit to Visakhapatnam, I trained Dilip Patro (another paraplegic who proved that a positive attitude was important to overcome disability) and he in turn is teaching it to others," he said.

His mother Virginia Sigworth and his friend and classmate George have accompanied him on four of his six visits to India after the accident.

"You know the meaning of life when living with disability. We have a capability of reminding normal persons of the value of life. I met many wealthy people who only spend on themselves. Only those who suffer can help others," he says.

A student of English literature, Jonathan took a year off studies to make a video film 'More than walking' to inspire others.

"Just because we can't walk, we shouldn't lose hope, as there are numerous other possibilities, depending on their level of injury," says Jonathan.

Reference Link
http://www.hindu.com/2010/03/14/stories/2010031452520300.htm

Courtesy
The Hindu

Tagged with: Andhra Pradesh, India, Jonathan Sigworth, paraplegics, Visakhapatnam

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'Positive attitude can work wonders for paraplegics'

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Jonathan Sigworth from the US demonstrating bed movements for paraplegics at a workshop in Visakhapatnam on Friday.

VISAKHAPATNAM, India: A positive attitude and societal care and concern can work wonders in the lives of paraplegics, said the speakers at the inaugural session of the 2nd Annual Spinal Injury awareness meet, organised by The Ability People, here on Friday.

District Collector J. Syamala Rao, who participated as chief guest, called for awareness among spinal injury patients about the facilities available at present to mitigate their suffering at least to some extent. He also called for awareness among the general public about the condition so that they could deal with them in a more humane manner. He promised all possible support to the organisation on behalf of the Government. Rotary District Governor Ch. Kishore Kumar said that spinal injuries were being caused mostly by road accidents. He felt that road safety awareness was needed among motorists and other road users for preventing road accidents. He said that the Rotary would take up awareness programmes to bring down the incidence of accidents. He called for development of roads and pavements to make them user-friendly to paraplegics. He stressed on the importance of a positive attitude for patients to prove their worth.

Dr. Uday Kumar, Head of the Orthopaedics Department of King George Hospital, underlined the importance of rehabilitation of paraplegic patients. There was no guarantee that they would respond to treatment but a positive attitude would make them overcome their disability to a large extent.

He commended Dr. N.V.S. Kiran Kumar, founder of Krushi Orthopaedic Welfare Society, for adopting the Paraplegia Ward in KGH. Dilip Patro of The Ability People said that the motto of the organisation was rehabilitation of patients. Dr. Kiran Kumar gave a PowerPoint presentation on early surgical intervention in spinal injury rehabilitation. He advised patients not to give up hope. Jonathan Sigworth from the US gave a demonstration on mobility for paraplegics. He also screened a video film “More than walking” to inspire patients.

Reference Link
http://www.hindu.com/2010/03/13/stories/2010031365170300.htm

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